

LOTUS ZHANG

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Mixed-Methods Researcher with 9 years of academic and industry experience. Combines qualitative depth with quantitative rigor to inform product strategy in big tech and advance accessible, AI-driven innovation.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Microsoft Research Usability Researcher (Contract), Redmond, WA Sep 2025 - Oct 2025

Partnered with interdisciplinary teams to explore generative AI and emerging gaming interaction trends.

- Designed and led focus group research examining emerging gameplay models at MSR EPIC Lab.
- Drove end-to-end research process from literature review and study facilitation to data analysis, identifying key insights to inform AI-driven gaming innovations.

Google UX Research Intern, San Francisco, CA Jun 2024 - Sep 2024

Drove feature prioritization for YouTube by conducting mixed-methods research, establishing new company-wide accessible MaxDiff survey standards in the process.

- Designed and executed a large-scale MaxDiff survey (1,000+ users) to identify top-priority YouTube features, delivering actionable insights to product managers and design teams.
- Led cognitive interviews, usability testing, and survey experiments to develop an accessible MaxDiff survey format for Blind and low-vision users.
- Published the new accessible methodology in company-wide UXR handbooks; promoted it across teams to improve research inclusivity.

Meta Quantitative UX Research Intern, Seattle, WA Jun 2020 - Sep 2020

Led survey research to understand motivations driving harmful content and inform the design of content moderation tools.

- Authored an extensive literature review, synthesizing theoretical and practical guidance on hate-speech behaviors; the report informed survey design and became a reusable resource for the teams.
- Designed and conducted a large-scale survey and log analysis (de-identified) to uncover behavioral patterns and motivations behind policy-violating content.
- Engaged cross-functionally with data scientists, engineers, PMs, and researchers on recruitment strategy, project scoping, and sharing findings across product and policy teams.

University of Washington Graduate Researcher, Seattle, WA Sep 2019 - Dec 2025

Conducting accessibility-focused research to improve tool design for Blind and low-vision content creators.

- Leading mixed-methods studies to uncover creators' needs and accessibility requirements for creative tools.
- Designing, building, and evaluating AI-assisted tools to support accessible visual content creation.

EDUCATION

University of Washington, PhD in Human Centered Design & Engineering Sep 2019 - Dec 2025

University of British Columbia, BA in Computer Science & Psychology Jan 2014 - May 2019

SKILLS

User Research Methods: Interview, Survey, Usability Testing, Experiment, Prototyping, Accessibility

Technical Skills: Data Analysis (Python, R), Web & Mobile Development, AI Model Integration

SELECTED PROJECTS & PUBLICATIONS

- **ASSETS' 25** - Interviews and probe studies revealed accessibility gaps for blind creators, guiding AI-driven tool design.
- **CHI' 23** - Surveys (n=220) + interviews uncovered barriers in blind patrons' arts engagement, informing access design.
- **ASSETS' 20 (Best Paper)** - Dataset analysis (n=700+) benchmarked input performance across age and motor ability.